

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Tsunami

NATURAL HAZARDS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Near the coast, strong or long shaking, a sudden unusual sea rise or retreat, or a loud ocean roar can signal a tsunami. After shaking stops, move to high ground and inland immediately. Do not wait for an official warning when natural warning signs are present.

Do now.

**Protect during shaking**

01

Drop, Cover and Hold On first if the earthquake is still occurring.

**Follow evacuation signs**

02

Move uphill and inland along the designated route, on foot if roads are blocked.

**Stay off the shore**

03

Never go to watch waves or exposed seabed.

**Wait for clearance**

04

Stay out of the evacuation zone until authorities say it is safe.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use natural warning signs to move inland and uphill immediately after shaking. Walk if roads are jammed and a safe pedestrian route is available. Stay away from the shore through later waves; quiet water or lack of a broadcast is not an all-clear.

Watch for.

The first wave may not be largest. Dangerous currents can last for hours.

People & practical needs.

Account for children, older people, pets and anyone who needs assistance before moving. Keep shoes, medicines and a torch in the shelter area. Decide who helps whom and who carries the essential supplies; do not send a lone child to retrieve items. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: protect during shaking. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. The first wave may not be largest. Dangerous currents can last for hours.

Keep essentials within reach.

For tsunami, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Use natural warning signs to move inland and uphill immediately after shaking. Walk if roads are jammed and a safe pedestrian route is available. Stay away from the shore through later waves; quiet water or lack of a broadcast is not an all-clear. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Know coastal evacuation routes before visiting. Use designated vertical evacuation structures where local plans provide them.

First decision: Protect during shaking

Drop, Cover and Hold On first if the earthquake is still occurring. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Use natural warning signs to move inland and uphill immediately after shaking. Walk if roads are jammed and a safe pedestrian route is available. Stay away from the shore through later waves; quiet water or lack of a broadcast is not an all-clear. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

The first wave may not be largest. Dangerous currents can last for hours. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Near the coast, strong or long shaking, a sudden unusual sea rise or retreat, or a loud ocean roar can signal a tsunami. After shaking stops, move to high ground and inland immediately. Do not wait for an official warning when natural warning signs are present. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For tsunami, keep the specific hazard in view: The first wave may not be largest. Dangerous currents can last for hours.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Wait for clearance. Stay out of the evacuation zone until authorities say it is safe. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Tsunami · official guidance

<https://www.weather.gov/safety/tsunami>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/tsunami/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.